

MYTH 4: WEALTHY PEOPLE TAKE STUPID RISKS TO GET RICH QUICK

TRUTH: The average millionaire hits the \$1 million mark at 49 years old. This is after years—decades, in fact—of hard work. Only 5% of millionaires got there in ten years or less.

As I travel for speaking engagements and media appearances, I get the chance to talk to a lot of people about their wealth-building goals. One question I hear over and over again from all types of people is, “Chris, how do wealthy people get rich quickly? What should I be doing to put myself in the millionaire column in the next five years?” Whenever I hear this question, I can be sure of one thing: they won’t like my answer. The idea that wealthy people have some secret fast track to wealth is a myth. The typical millionaire, like the ones that may be hiding in your own neighborhood right now, didn’t strike it rich overnight. In fact, if someone earning the median US household income of \$59,000 started investing the recommended 15% of their income at age thirty, they’d have over \$1 million by age fifty-five.^{[10](#)} And that’s if they never got a single raise! Just doing the exact same thing for twenty-five years would make them a millionaire. Now, most people *do* get raises, and they’re able to contribute more to their investments over time. So, if that’s the case, they could get there faster than twenty-five years. But it’s not going to be immediate.

This example lines up with what we found in our research. We discovered that the average millionaire hits the \$1 million mark at 49 years old. That’s after decades of working, saving, and investing. Only 5% of millionaires got there in ten years or less. That’s the reality of building a \$1 million net worth. Yes, it’s absolutely possible, but it takes time. People don’t want a twenty- or thirty-year plan, though; they want a three-year plan. But that’s not how most millionaires made their money. When it comes to building wealth, the microwave approach doesn’t cut it.